

Staging the Page: The Adaptation Project

Introduction

This course – *Translations from Page to Screen* – sits at the intersection of literacy studies and media studies, analyzing the relationship between written texts and their screen adaptations as both the subject of inquiry and the vehicle for developing students as analytical writers and critical thinkers.

By this point in the semester, we have explored the power of words across mediums and sharpened our study into a more focused question: *What happens when a story crosses from one medium to another, and what do the choices made in that transition reveal about the relationship between form and meaning?* That question should drive your thinking as you prepare to complete this assignment.

This project is the culmination of everything you have studied and practiced throughout our time together. It is designed in phases, meaning you will have minor deadlines, which you can find below, before it is officially due on **December 18th**.

Deadlines

- Phase 0: Proposal (due **on** November 11th)
- Phase 1: Check-In Chat (due **by** November 24th)
- Phase 2: Draft (due **on** December 4th)
- Phase 3: Final Adaptation Project Due (due **on** December 18th)

Think of these “phases” as an opportunity to talk through your ideas and aspirations with me. As you prepare to submit your proposal in the coming weeks, please note that I encourage you to revisit your work earlier in the semester, including my feedback. While this project requires you to select a text you have not previously worked on, perhaps an earlier submission may provide inspiration. I specifically encourage you to look at your textual analysis essay, visual analysis exercise, Adaptation Choice Simulator assignment, and the several discussion posts you have completed throughout the semester. You may use any one of these assignments as a springboard for which to develop your thinking for this project. As always, you have access to our readings, which I’ve outlined below for your convenience. **If you have any questions, do not hesitate to reach out to me at el170335@ucf.edu or schedule an appointment to meet during office hours.**

Helpful Resources:

On Adaptations:

- Selected Readings from *A Theory of Adaptation* by Linda Hutcheon
- Selected Readings from *The Death of the Author* by Roland Barthes

On Crafting a Screenplay:

- *Screenplay* by Syd Field
- *Save the Cat* by Black Snyder

Other:

- *Arrival* Screenplay by Eric Heisserer
- “Stories of Your Life and Others” by Ted Chiang

Assignment Overview

As you know, stories don’t exist in only one form. Every time a story crosses from one medium to another, someone makes hundreds of deliberate choices – about what to keep, what to cut, what to change, and what tone to strike – and every one of those decisions is an argument for what the story is about. The Adaptation Project is designed as the culminating assignment of this course. It is my hope that you will turn something in you are genuinely proud of – a piece of work that demonstrates not just that you can analyze a text, but that you understand *why* that analysis matters in a world where the stories we tell and the forms in which we tell them are in constant motion.

This assignment asks you to examine **a text pairing of your choice** closely. This can be a written source and its screen adaptation, such as a novel or short story and its cinematic counterpart, **OR** a source text *you* will adapt yourself. You will then complete one of two options below:

Option A: The Analytical Essay

Write a **1500–2000-word analytical essay** in which you identify a specific interpretive question raised by your chosen adaptation and build a researched argument in response to it.

The best analytical essays for this assignment won’t ask whether an adaptation is “good” or “bad” – they will ask what a specific adaptation choice does, what it costs, and what it reveals about the source material, the filmmaker’s intentions, or the audience the film was made for.

You should choose a pairing you find genuinely interesting because the quality of your argument will depend on how carefully and curiously you have read both texts.

Strong Essays Will:

- Identify specific adaptation choice(s) and analyze what it accomplishes or sacrifices in relation to the source.
- Apply course vocabulary to discuss both the literary and cinematic techniques at work in the scene(s) you've chosen to examine.
- Ground every claim in specific textual evidence – quoted passages from the source, described or cited scenes from the film, etc.
- Incorporate at least two secondary sources (scholarly articles, critical essays, or substantive published reviews, etc.) that inform, complicate, or support your argument.
- Be organized around a central claim that is specific, arguable, and maintained throughout the essay.

Option B: The Creative Adaptation with Critical Reflection

Produce your own adaptation of a written source text, moving it from one medium to another. Seeing as this is a film-themed ENC1101 course, I expect most of you to convert your chosen written text into a screenplay and/or storyboard. If you wish to pursue a different path, please consult me first.

Submit the **creative work** (completed screenplay and/or storyboard of selected scene(s)) alongside an **800-1000-word critical reflection** that analyzes the choices you made.

This option is **NOT** easier than Option A. You are being tasked with what filmmakers, showrunners, and screenwriters do: make hundreds of small decisions that add up to a coherent adaptation and then account for these choices with the same analytical rigor the essay requires. The **reflection** is where your choices become apparent, where you will be able to “defend” the choices you made in translating your selected source – and it will be held to the same standards as Option A’s argument.

The Creative Component Might Be:

- Scenes(s) or chapter(s) from a novel, short story, or graphic novel adapted into screenplay format.
- A song, poem, or short prose piece adapted into a longer narrative or scene(s).
- A short story adapted into a visual medium: a storyboard accompanied by an annotated shot list OR a graphic narrative.
- Another form proposed and approved by Professor Diaz Pena.

The Critical Reflection Must:

- Identify and explain at least three specific adaptation choices you made while using course vocabulary.
- Analyze what each choice preserves, transforms, or sacrifices from the source text.
- Reflect honestly on what the process revealed about the relationship between medium and meaning. The core question here is: *What did you understand about the source differently after attempting to adapt it?*

Assignment Structure and Timeline

As previously mentioned, this project will unfold in several phases. Each phase builds on the last, and you will receive written feedback before the next phase is due.

Phase 0: Proposal (due on November 11th)

Submit a 300-500-word proposal that includes the following:

- Your chosen text pairing (Option A) or source text (Option B).
- Which option you are pursuing and a brief description of your angle or interpretive focus.
- A short artificial intelligence plan of action: How do you intend to use AI in your process? What won't you use AI for?
- **For Option B:** A brief description of the medium you plan to adapt into and an explanation why you chose it.

Phase 1: Check-In Chat (due by November 24th)

By the provided date, I should have spoken to each of you about your projects, including ideas, brainstorming, and doubts. This **15-minute conversation** is to help move you along in the process. It's intentionally informal and low stakes, but I expect you to be able to sustain a conversation about your chosen text and/or lens for adaptation.

Phase 2: Draft (due on December 4th)

Submit a **complete draft** of your essay or creative component with reflection. The draft will be evaluated using the same rubric as the final submission. You are expected to demonstrate **meaningful revision** between your draft and final submission.

Phase 3: Final Adaptation Project Due (due on December 18th)

Submit your **revised draft** of your essay or creative project with reflection. Include a revision note (one paragraph) identifying the most significant changes you made between your draft and this version and explaining *why* you made them.

***Note:** The revision note is graded as part of the Writing Quality and Revision.*

Specific Guidelines for Using AI

Artificial intelligence tools are a real part of the academic landscape we are being trained to navigate, and this course does not pretend otherwise. This assignment does not ban AI – instead, I ask that you use AI thoughtfully and account for it transparently.

Earlier in the course, we examined how AI is a particular kind of reader, one with real pattern-recognition capabilities but also one with real blind spots. Understanding what AI does and does not do well is itself an act of media literacy, and is a core learning objective of this course, as seen through our earlier exercise on *Arrival* and book covers. The requirements below ask you to carry the same criteria and perception we used then into your writing process now.

Permitted Uses

- Using the Adaptation Choice Simulator (or a similar AI tool) during the planning stage to generate possible approaches.
- Using AI to brainstorm possible interpretive angles or identify scenes that might merit comparison – as a starting point that you will then investigate.
- Using AI to clarify course terminology or check your understanding of a technical concept.
- Using AI to help format citations or check bibliographic information.

Prohibited Uses

- Submitting AI-generated analytical or creative writing as your own work. This includes using AI to draft any portion of your essay, creative component, reflection, or revision note.
- Using AI to complete the close reading this assignment demands of you.

Documentation Requirements

- In your planning, you will submit your “AI Plan of Action.” With your final draft, you will submit a brief AI Usage Statement (approximately 150-200 words) detailing which AI tools you used, if any, and what you used each tool for.
- You must be specific in telling me what the AI tools were used for. For example, do not say, “I used Claude for brainstorming.” Do say, “I used the Adaptation Choice Simulator to generate four possible approaches for the opening scene of my passage, then I rejected two of them because they did not....” **If unsure, contact Professor Diaz Pena with questions or concerns.**

Assessment Rubric

Both options are assessed on the same four criteria. For Option B, the critical reflection will be assessed within the Textual Analysis and Strength of Argument columns, while the creative component itself will be evaluated for intentionality, coherence, and effort.

Criteria	Excellent 100-90%	Proficient 89-75%	Developing 74-60%	Beginning Below 60%
Textual Analysis	Reads closely and precisely. Claims are well-supported. Analysis moves beyond summary to effectively interpret how techniques produce meaning.	Reads carefully with mostly specific evidence. Analysis generally moves beyond summary, though some moments remain descriptive. Both mediums are addressed.	Evidence is present but sometimes general or loosely connected to claims. Analysis frequently summarizes. One medium may be underexplored.	Little or no specific textual evidence. Writing largely summarizes plot or scenes without analytical interpretation. Relationship between technique and meaning is not addressed.
Strength of Argument	Central claim is specific, original, and well-defended throughout. The student avoids oversimplification and provides a complex argument. Effectively addresses the	Central claim is clear and mostly developed. Argument is coherent but may lack focus or may oversimplify certain points. Addresses the stakes of chosen interpretation.	A claim is present but may be too broad, apparent, or inconsistently supported. Argument drifts and relies on assertion rather than evidence. The stakes of interpretation	No clear central claim, or claim is a restatement. Writing lacks a clear argumentative goal and reads as summary or personal reaction rather than analysis.

	stakes of chosen interpretation.		are not well discussed.	
Course Vocabulary	Applies literary and cinematic terminology accurately and consistently. Demonstrates ease moving between frameworks for each medium.	Uses course vocabulary accurately in most instances. Using terminology meaningfully, though sometimes lacks proper analysis.	Some course vocabulary is used but it is either inconsistent or incorrect. Terminology may be dropped without being developed.	Little or no course vocabulary used or terminology is consistently misunderstood. No meaningful distinction made between unique mediums.
Writing Quality and Revision	Writing is clear, organized, and full of voice. Final submission shows substantive, meaningful revisions. Revision note demonstrates genuine self-reflection.	Writing is generally clear with minor lapses in organization or style. Revision is visible and purposeful, if not always substantial. Revision note identifies changes.	Writing contains noticeable clarity or organizational issues that affect readability. Revision between draft and original is minimal. Revision note is vague or lacks reflection.	Writing is unclear or disorganized in ways that impede comprehension. Little to no evidence of revision. Lacks a revision note or is incomplete.